Evaluation

Constructivism can be said to be epistemologically about the social construction of knowledge and ontologically about the construction of social reality. The basic aim therefore, what seems of constructivism is increasing the reflexivity in both theoretical and empirical studies in IR on the basis the fact that analysis of the social world is very much a part of the real world and might affect it also. A constructivist looks at international relations with an eye open to social construction of actors, institutions and events. However, it does not mean that constructivism sets aside the ideas that material power is important or that actors make instrumental calculations of their interests; nor does it necessarily assume the *apriori* existence of sovereign states, epistemological positivism, or the anarchy problematique. Rather, it means that what goes on in these categories and concepts is constructed by social processes and interactions, and that their relevance for international relations is a function of the social construction of meaning. For example, the realist assumptions for competitions among states may be for status, prestige, hegemony but they will only make sense in terms of either legitimized power or shared understandings or are constructed. Therefore, a constructivists analysis opens a space for greater reflexivity in the analysis of any situation or event in international relations where the actors can for a moment think how their own actions may contribute to the very problems they seek to address. The glaring example in the recent international politics is the US War on Terror. What started as a largely militarized response to the 9/11 attack in the US, but later has assumed politicization of the US actions, and later the mission of remaking countries of Middle-east into liberal democracies involving human rights violations, disregard of international law and thus War on Terror becoming a war of infinite duration. A Constructivist approach to this War on Terror would rather emphasize on how identities and human sufferings are constructed through a process of interaction and move away from the emphasis on states.